

Fixing Comma Splices — 9th Grade, 30 Minutes

Diagnose & Repair — Comma Splices

The Cover Test: Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Cover everything before. Complete sentence too? If yes to both — you have a splice. Pick a fix.

Three fixes:

1. Add a conjunction !', and / , but / , so / , yet
2. Upgrade the comma !';
3. Split it !'.

Exercise 1

Fix this comma splice using **any method you choose**.

| The new phone costs over a thousand dollars, most students can't afford it.

Which fix did you use? Circle one: conjunction semicolon period

Exercise 2

Fix this comma splice by **adding a conjunction**.

| Climate change affects coastal cities, many are investing in flood barriers.

Which conjunction did you choose, and why?

Exercise 3

Fix this comma splice using **a semicolon**.

| He wanted to try out for the team, he was nervous about the competition.

Exercise 4

Write your own sentence that joins two independent clauses correctly. Use a **comma + conjunction**. Underline the conjunction.

Back of page — Transfer

Find one comma splice in something you have already written. Copy it here, then fix it.

Original (with the splice):

Fixed:

Fix I used: conjunction / semicolon / period

Fixing Comma Splices

Slides — 11 slides · 26 min · English 9

1. Fixing Comma Splices · 1 min

One error. Three fixes. Five seconds each.

Notes: Let them read the subtitle. Say: 'By the end of today you will be able to spot this error in anything you write and fix it three different ways. That is the whole lesson.' Do not explain more yet.

2. What is a comma splice? · 2 min

A comma splice happens when you join two complete sentences with only a comma. A comma is not strong enough to hold two full sentences together.

Notes: Read it aloud slowly. Ask: 'What does complete sentence mean?' Take two answers. You want them to land on: subject + verb + a thought that could stand alone. Do not move on until that is in the room.

3. Spot the splice · 2 min

Comma splice — The album dropped at midnight, fans crashed the streaming servers.

Fixed — The album dropped at midnight, and fans crashed the streaming servers.

Notes: Show the left side only first — click or cover the right. Ask: 'Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Now cover everything before. Complete sentence? Two complete sentences, one comma — that is the splice.' Then reveal the fix. Ask: 'What one word did we add?'

4. The Cover Test · 1 min

Cover everything after the comma. Complete sentence? Cover everything before. Complete sentence too? If yes to both — you have a splice. Now pick a fix.

Notes: This is the diagnostic move. Have them repeat it back to you in their own words before you move to the three fixes. Cold-call two students.

5. Three ways to fix a splice · 1 min

- Add a conjunction: , and / , but / , so / , yet
- Swap the comma for a semicolon: ;
- Split into two sentences: use a period

Notes: Point at each bullet and give the one-word version: 'Join it. Upgrade it. Split it.' Ask them to say those three words with you. They will remember the words before they remember the grammar terms.

6. Fix 2 — the semicolon · 2 min

Comma splice — The coach called a timeout, the players were exhausted.

Fixed — The coach called a timeout; the players were exhausted.

Notes: Ask: 'Why does the semicolon work here?' Draw out: the two ideas are closely related — the timeout and the exhaustion belong together. A period would work too, but the semicolon signals the connection. Ask when they might prefer a period instead.

7. Fix 3 — the period · 1 min

Comma splice — I finished my essay early, I decided to revise it one more time.

Fixed — I finished my essay early. I decided to revise it one more time.

Notes: Ask: 'Could we use a conjunction here? A semicolon?' Yes to both — so why choose the period? Sometimes clean separation is the strongest choice. The period is not a last resort; it is a real option. This is where students stop defaulting to 'and' for everything.

8. Your turn — handout exercises 1–3 · 6 min

- Work with your partner.
- Fix each sentence.
- Use a different method from the one your partner used first.
- Be ready to explain why your fix works.

Notes: Hand out the Diagnose & Repair handout now if you have not already. Set a 6-minute timer visibly. Circulate and watch for students who fix every splice with a period — nudge: 'Can you try the semicolon on that one?'

9. Exercise 4 — write your own · 4 min

- Write one sentence with two independent clauses.
- Join them correctly with a comma + conjunction.
- Underline the conjunction.

Notes: Solo work, 4 minutes. If a student finishes fast, ask them to write a second version using a semicolon instead. Cold-call two students to read theirs aloud when time is up.

10. Find it in your own writing · 3 min

Open something you have already written. Find one comma splice and fix it on the back of your handout. No splice? Write one on purpose — then fix it.

Notes: 3 minutes. This is the transfer move — the whole lesson builds to this. If students say they cannot find one, that is fine: writing one intentionally and fixing it is the same skill. Walk the room and ask two or three students what they found.

11. Exit ticket · 3 min

Open the exit ticket in Yawp before you pack up.

Notes: 3 minutes. Students should be able to name what a comma splice is and describe at least one fix. While they write, sort the handouts into two piles: found a splice in their own writing vs. did not. That split tells you who needs another round tomorrow.

Exit ticket: what a comma splice is and how to fix it

In your own words, explain what a comma splice is and how to fix it. Write it the way you would explain it to someone who missed class today — not the definition you were given, but what you actually understand it to mean.

Write as much as you can, and go further than your first sentence — the more you explain your thinking, the more this is worth. Don't worry about polish. This is about what you understand, not how neatly you say it.